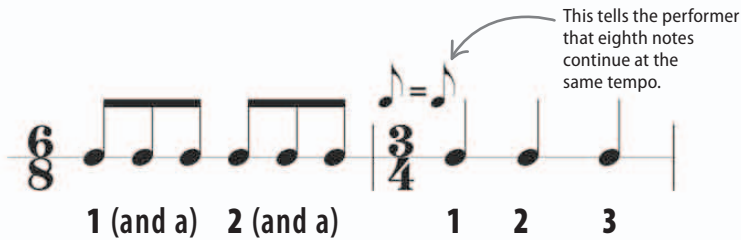


Changing time signature

Sometimes composers like to swap between different rhythms and meters. Complex modern music may have many changes of time signature. The example below switches from 6/8 to 3/4. Both these time signatures have six eighth notes per measure, but the beats and emphases are different.

▽ "America"

"America" from *West Side Story* by Leonard Bernstein has this type of rhythm. The change of meter adds energy and excitement.



REAL WORLD

Polyrhythms

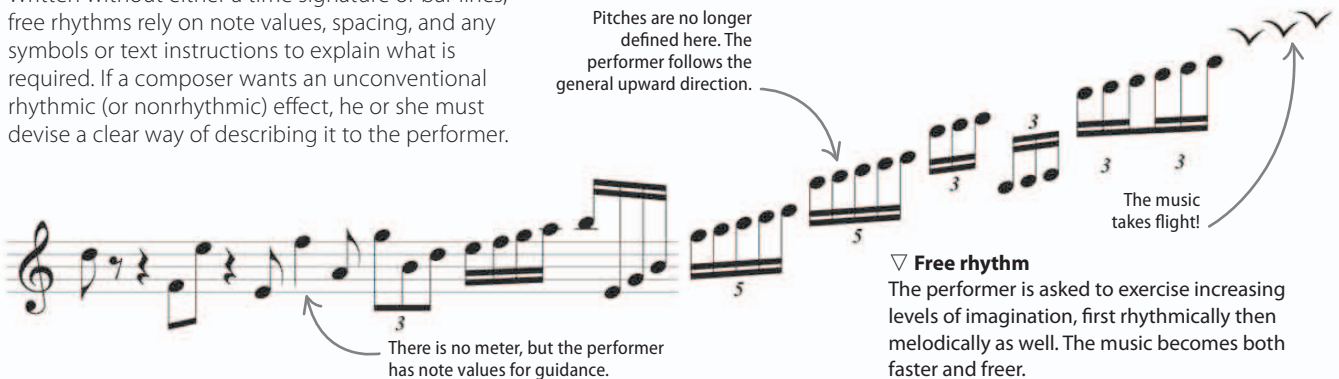
Sometimes different rhythms and meters are played at the same time by different instruments. Some styles of West African traditional drum music use polyrhythms that combine several layers of drum patterns, each played by a different type of drum.



Ghanaian drum

Free rhythms

Written without either a time signature or bar lines, free rhythms rely on note values, spacing, and any symbols or text instructions to explain what is required. If a composer wants an unconventional rhythmic (or nonrhythmic) effect, he or she must devise a clear way of describing it to the performer.



▽ Free rhythm

The performer is asked to exercise increasing levels of imagination, first rhythmically then melodically as well. The music becomes both faster and freer.

Swing

Swing rhythms are written in simple time, but played "with a swing", as if in triplets or compound time. Each pair of eighth notes is played with a longer first note and a shorter second note. This way of playing can be indicated simply by putting "Swing" at the start, with the tempo, or by using the notational key shown on the right.



◁ Swing instruction

This instruction can be written at the start of a piece, above the staff. It tells the player to use a swing rhythm.

▷ Performing swing

This example shows a 4/4 bar of eighth notes as written, then as played in a swing rhythm.

Swing



Written as

Performed as